

Surprisingly, the Canon LBP 2900 was more expensive to use in this regard despite being one of the cheapest printers. It sets you back by Rs 1.74 per page.

So it is clear that the speed and quality of the Canon 2900 comes at a slight premium in terms of cost per page. Though a difference of 60 paise might not seem like much, when you extrapolate this over the life of a toner, you end up spending Rs 1,200 more per toner than with the Canon 3200. The cost per page becomes a deciding factor for businesses that have high volumes of printing.

Conclusion

As you may have guessed, the fight was extremely close. The verdict is that the Canon LBP 2900 just about edged out the Lexmark E 230 to take the *Digit* 'Best Buy Gold' award.

The Lexmark E 230 was a surprise winner here. We thought it would lose out hugely in terms of speed but it seemed it had more than made up for it in terms of quality, features and price. So, the *Digit* 'Best Buy Silver' award goes to the Lexmark E230.

WORKGROUP LASER PRINTERS

Having just finished working with printers from the SoHo category, one startling difference we noticed when moving on to workgroup printers was the size. Not all of these printers were as compact as the previous category—the Samsung 2551N and Brother 6050D, for instance seem to be saying “bigger is better”.

Since our last test with inkjets, the Brother



Samsung 1520P

printers have improved incredibly in terms of ease of installation. There were no hiccups this time around, and even the earlier infamous Brother installer program has been improved upon. The signs are encouraging!

It was Samsung, though, that won the ease-of-installation award! There's AI at work for sure, because the installer just magically does everything quickly and automatically without any nagging questions or instructions.

In contrast, the Brother installer prompts you to connect the printer, and if you tried to be cheeky and connected it earlier, the printer is just not detected.

Feature Set

In terms of resolution, the Samsung ML 2250 and 2551N were the only ones to offer a real 1,200 x 1,200 resolution, while the rest managed 600 dpi.

In terms of paper tray capacity, the Samsung 2551N and the Brother HL-6050D were way ahead of the competition and provided a 500-page tray as compared to 250 pages for the majority and a mere 150 for the WeP 2500. Except for the WeP 2500, all printers provided an option of adding another tray to boost paper input capacity.

One feature that was found sorely missing on Samsung's 2250 and 2551N as well as the Xerox 3420P, was automatic duplex printing. All other printers offered this.

In terms of the bundled accessories, almost all printers were similar, except for the Brother HL 5170DN, which did not have a data cable, and the WeP 2500, which came with a parallel data cable.

As for operating system support, every printer in this category supported Windows, Linux and Mac. The exception was the WeP 2500, which also had support for Unix—the only printer we've come across in all categories to offer this.

For a workgroup printer, a screen is essential, because you need to be able to set certain functions without having to muck around with the printer drivers.

The Brother HL 5170DN, Samsung 2250 and WeP 2500 were the only ones without one. While the lack of a screen is forgivable in the SoHo category owing to lower prices, it is sacrosanct for a Workgroup printer.

Buying Guide

When buying a laser printing device, you must consider your options carefully. Unlike software, there are no upgrades to features, so if you miss out on a feature that you may require later, you have no option but to buy a new device.

Options You Should Look For

At the end of the day, a couple of seconds here and there in terms of printing speeds don't really make much of a difference, but what matters really are the features provided 'on-board'.

Duplex Printing: This means printing on both sides of the printer automatically. This option is very important as printing on only one side of the paper is a waste, and results in increased paper costs. A lot of laser printers come with Automatic Duplex print as an option, and should be preferred over printers that don't have this feature, or only provide manual duplex—you need to manually flip the paper and put it back in the printer.

Networking: This is extremely important if you are using your printer in a business or SoHo environment, where multiple users need to be able to print using one printer. You can just set up and share a networking printer and allow all users to print directly to the printer. Some printers offer networking as an option, so you need not pay for the feature now, but you need it later you can add a network card.

Memory Buffer: This feature becomes important when considering a networked printer. You should have an adequate memory buffer to speed up the printing process if a lot of people will be using the printer.

Additional Paper Trays: As your company grows, your printing needs too, will grow. You should look for a printer that allows you to add additional paper trays, so that people are saved the hassle of filling up the paper tray.

Size: Although not as important as the first four aspects, size does matter, especially if your office is small and space is at a premium. Bigger devices can generally handle heavier workloads, so factor this in as well according to your company's printing requirements.

Keep the points mentioned above in mind when making your final decision. Choosing the right device can save you a lot of hassle and money in the long run.